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HOW DOES SPACE, OR THE LACK OF IT, WRING OUR RELATIONSHIPS? HOW DOES PLACE CONTOUR OUR PERSONALITY? When and how does a room morph from a location into a protagonist? What do escape and freedom mean? And is there escape without guilt? These are just some of the questions that Manil Suri, author of three novels and a book on popular mathematics, probes in his memoir, *A Room in Bombay*.



FAMILY HAPPINESS Manil Suri with his parents in Bombay



A ROOM IN BOMBAY: A Memoir
By Manil Suri
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹699; 352 pages

When we speak, Suri is in Pittsburgh, attending a literary festival. The Booker-longlisted author says that while he struggles with plot in fiction, in a memoir the plot was already laid out for him. He often found he had "too much plot", as so much had happened to him. He grew up in a derelict apartment in Bombay, which his parents, Ram and Prem, shared with three Muslim families. The families used a common kitchen and bathroom, which often led to heated skirmishes. His parents were caught in a loveless and humourless marriage, and from a young age Suri became peacekeeper, accountant, cheerleader and soother of broken spirits. In the confines of Razia Mansion, as a friendless child, he realised he might be gay. At the age of 20, he finally admitted to his mother—"I couldn't do it anymore. The flat was killing me; I couldn't stay"—and left for the US.

Suri elaborates on the grip of the room: "The room did have this clutching quality to it, like it had all of us in its grasp. And it was both a place that was somewhere to escape from all the hostility around us, but

BOOKS ▼

KNOWING YOUR PLACE

DREAMS ARE DASHED IN THE FEUDAL PAKISTAN DEPICTED IN **DANIYAL MUEENUDDIN**'S *THIS IS WHERE THE SERPENT LIVES*

It's strange to think of Daniyal Mueenuddin, an already much-heralded writer, as a debut novelist. Back in 2009, his brilliant collection of short stories, *In Other Rooms, Other Wonders*, was a finalist for both a Pulitzer prize and the United States' National Book Award. Mueenuddin's stories recreated, with verve, insight and genuine feeling, his unusual experience as the scion of a landowning family in Pakistani Punjab who returned from the United States to run his farm.

This understanding gives his voice authority. You believe what he is telling you in this novel, about life in grand houses and squalid lean-tos, about life as a wealthy, art-buying, Turgenev-reading housewife, a diffident America-returned scion, a corpulent munshi, an orphan who rises to become a trusted driver to the boss, a favoured servant undone by ambition, a prickly gangster at once contemptuous and covetous of the trappings of the old order and so on.

The problem, though, is that Mueenuddin's understanding, his intimacy with Pakistan's still extant feudal structure, prevents him, or



THIS IS WHERE THE SERPENT LIVES
By Daniyal Mueenuddin
PENGUIN INDIA/HAMISH HAMILTON
₹699; 368 pages